

A Handshake, and Its Limits

Lesson 33 — The Oslo Accords and their collapse

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain the specific conditions on both sides that made secret negotiation possible in 1993

2

Describe what the Oslo Accords actually agreed, and what they deliberately deferred

3

Trace the process's collapse from Rabin's assassination to the Second Intifada

4

Evaluate competing historiographical explanations for why Oslo ultimately failed

A new decade, a new diplomatic opening

The Gulf War reshuffled regional alliances and reduced Cold War pressures on Middle Eastern diplomacy. This block covers what followed: a genuine attempt at Israeli-Palestinian peace, the rise of political Islam as a rival force, and the path toward a new Iraq war entirely.

Two exhausted, weakened parties

Israel's 1982 Lebanon War and the ongoing First Intifada, beginning in 1987, convinced even Yitzhak Rabin — as defence minister, no less — that the conflict had no purely military solution. Arafat's PLO, meanwhile, had backed Saddam Hussein's 1990 invasion of Kuwait, alienating its wealthy Gulf financial backers and leaving the organisation financially and diplomatically weakened, more willing to accept a limited deal than at any earlier point.

Secret talks in Norway

While an official, more rigid Israeli-Palestinian delegation negotiated openly in Washington, a separate, unofficial channel of PLO and Israeli academics and officials met secretly in Oslo, proving far more flexible. Even the American government was reportedly unaware how serious these Norwegian-brokered talks had become until an agreement was nearly complete.

13 September 1993, Washington

“Enough of blood and tears. Enough!”

Yitzhak Rabin, addressing Palestinians at the Declaration of Principles signing ceremony, Washington DC.

Mutual recognition, and a five-year interim plan

The PLO recognised Israel's right to exist, renounced terrorism, and pledged to amend its founding charter; Israel recognised the PLO as the Palestinians' legitimate representative. The Declaration of Principles set out a five-year interim period of Palestinian self-government, beginning in Gaza and Jericho, with the hardest questions — borders, Jerusalem, refugees, and settlements — deliberately deferred to later “final status” negotiations.

Cairo, and then Oslo II

The May 1994 Cairo Agreement enacted the first stage, transferring Gaza and Jericho to Palestinian control. The September 1995 Oslo II (Taba) Agreement divided the wider West Bank into three types of area — full Palestinian control, joint control, and full Israeli control — a patchwork arrangement whose complexity itself created new friction on the ground.

‘Land and economics in exchange for security’

The accords' basic logic asked Israel to trade limited territorial and economic autonomy for improved security, delivered through a new Palestinian police force policing its own population. Rabin himself candidly suggested the Palestinian Authority might fight terrorism more effectively than Israel could, unconstrained by Israeli human rights oversight — an arrangement some observers, even at the time, saw as ethically troubling.

Attacks from both extremes

Hamas and Islamic Jihad, opposed to any recognition of Israel, launched a sustained campaign of attacks on Israeli civilians between 1993 and 1997. In February 1994, an Israeli settler murdered dozens of Muslim worshippers at Hebron's Tomb of the Patriarchs — violence from opposite directions, both aimed at derailing the same process.

4 November 1995

Yigal Amir, a right-wing Israeli opposed to Oslo on religious and nationalist grounds, assassinated Rabin at a peace rally. A wave of subsequent Hamas attacks helped tip Israel's 1996 election toward Likud's Benjamin Netanyahu, whose party had long opposed both Palestinian statehood and territorial withdrawal.

Settlements grew throughout the peace process

Despite Oslo's stated aim of eventual Palestinian self-determination, the Israeli settler population in the occupied territories grew substantially throughout these very years — a trend that continued under multiple governments regardless of their formal commitment to the peace process, and one many Palestinians point to as evidence of bad faith.

Camp David, July 2000

President Clinton convened Israeli Prime Minister Ehud Barak and Arafat at Camp David to attempt a final settlement. Despite further Israeli concessions beyond any earlier offer, the two sides remained fundamentally divided over borders, Jerusalem's status, and Palestinian refugees' claimed “right of return”. The summit ended without agreement.

Whose fault was Camp David's failure?

One account holds that Arafat rejected a genuinely historic offer and bears primary responsibility for the summit's failure and the violence that followed. A competing account argues Barak's offer, while significant, still fell well short of full Palestinian sovereignty — proposing Israeli annexation of part of the West Bank and no right of return — and that accepting it might have been politically impossible for Arafat to survive.

The Second Intifada begins

On 28 September 2000, a visit by Likud leader Ariel Sharon to Jerusalem's Temple Mount triggered riots that rapidly escalated into the sustained, far bloodier violence known as the Second, or al-Aqsa, Intifada — effectively ending the Oslo process as a functioning framework, even though its interim structures technically remained in place.

Was Oslo ever designed to succeed fully?

Historian Seth Anziska has argued the Accords' vision of limited Palestinian autonomy traces directly back to Menachem Begin's 1978 Camp David framework, which explicitly rejected full Palestinian statehood from the outset — suggesting Oslo's structural limits were a deliberate legacy, not simply a failure of implementation or bad luck.

A full essay attempt

'The Oslo Accords failed primarily because of structural limitations built into the agreement itself, not because of specific decisions made by individual leaders after 1993.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence: the deferred final-status issues, settlement growth, and Camp David's collapse
- Address the strongest counter-argument — that specific choices, not structure, mattered most — before concluding

Key terms from today

Declaration of Principles

The September 1993 founding document of the Oslo process.

Areas A, B, and C

Oslo II's division of West Bank control between Israel and the Palestinian Authority.

Final status issues

Borders, Jerusalem, refugees, and settlements — deliberately deferred by Oslo.

Al-Aqsa Intifada

The uprising beginning September 2000 that effectively ended the process.

What to remember

The Oslo Accords achieved genuine, historic mutual recognition between Israel and the PLO, built from mutual exhaustion and weakness rather than shared vision — but deferred every genuinely difficult question to a later date that violence, assassination, and continued settlement growth ultimately foreclosed. Whether this reflected the accords' own structural limits or specific human failures remains a live historiographical debate.

Lesson 34 — The rise of political Islam

Next lesson: how Hamas, Hezbollah, and a revived Muslim Brotherhood offered an alternative political vision across the region — one Oslo's secular nationalist framework increasingly struggled to compete with.